

Session 22: God's Lament

Key Takeaways

- Genesis 14-19 continues the pattern of narrative sections culminating in densely packed poems. God's curse is upon the snake and the ground, not on humanity.
- Conflict will exist between the seed of the woman and the seed of the snake, but the ultimate victory is over the snake—our enemy is never another human.

God's Lament: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 3:14-19

The Snake Is Cursed

14 and Yahweh God said to the snake ,
" Because you have done this thing ,
you are cursed more than every beast and more than every living creature of the field
on your belly you will go,
and dust you will eat .
all the days of your life.

Consequences For The Woman

15 And I will set hostility
a between you and the woman ,
a' and between your seed and her seed ,
b he will strike your head
b' and you will strike his heel."

16 and to the woman he said ,
a "I will greatly multiply your grief and your conception ,
a' in grief you will birth children ,
b and your desire will be for your husband,
b' and he will rule over you."

Consequences For The Man

17 and to human he said ,
" Because you have listened to the voice of your wife,

and **you ate** from the tree about which I commanded you, saying,
' **You will** not **eat** from it.'
cursed is the **ground** on account of you;
in grief **you will eat** from it
all the days of your life.

- a 18 thorns and thistles it shall sprout for you;
b and **you will eat** the plants of the field;
a' 19 by the sweat of your face
b' **you will eat** bread,
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- a until you return to the **ground**
b for from **it** you were taken;
b' for you are **dust**
a' and to **dust** you will return.

Genesis 3:14-19. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).

"Although much can be said about the curse on the snake, the woman, and the man, it is important to note that the text says very little. In this passage we can see most clearly the artful composition that produced the Pentateuch. ... The narrative gives nothing to help us understand their plight as individuals. The snake, the woman, and the man are not depicted as individuals involved in a personal crisis; rather, they are representatives. We are left with the impression that this is not their story so much as it is our story, the story of humankind. With great skill the author has presented these three participants as the heads of their race. The snake on the one hand and the man and the woman on the other are as two great nations embarking on a great struggle, a struggle that will find its conclusion only by an act of some distant and as yet unidentified 'seed.'"

Sailhamer, John H. (1995). [*The Pentateuch as Narrative: A Biblical-theological Commentary*](#). Zondervan Academic.

Poems as Summary Literary Markers

The poetic speech of God makes clear a pattern that has already been at work in Genesis 1-3. This pattern will continue for the rest of the book of Genesis and on through the large narrative work of the Torah and Former Prophets (Genesis-2 Kings).

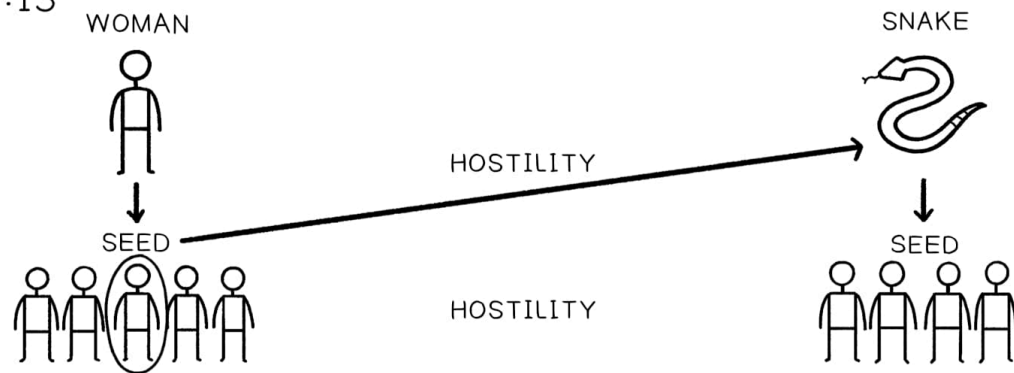
Strategic narratives in the Torah often begin or conclude with poems that condense the core themes and images of the surrounding stories while carrying the plot forward. These poems occur on the micro level within individual stories, but they also occur at the macro level that determines the larger plot and themes of the entire story of the Torah and Prophets.

Reference	Embedded Poem	
Genesis 1:1-2:3	Image of God poem	1:27
Genesis 2:4-24	Song of Adam about Eve	2:23
Genesis 3:14-19	Curses add consequences	3:14-19
Genesis 4:1-26	Lemek's murderous boast	4:23-24
Genesis 5:1-9:28	Noah's farewell speech	9:25-27
Genesis 10:1-11:32	God's promise to Abram	12:1-3
Genesis 24:1-67	Farewell blessing for Rebekah	24:60
Genesis 25:19-34	Rebekah's birth oracle	25:23
Genesis 27:1-28:7	Isaac's blessing for Jacob	27:27-29
Genesis 37:1-50:26	Jacob's farewell speech	49:1-28
Exodus 1:1-15:21	Song of the Sea	15:1-22
Numbers 22:1-24:25	Balaam's oracles of blessing	23:7-10 23:18-24 24:2-9 24:15-24
Deuteronomy 1-34	Moses' final warning speech	32:1-43
	Moses' farewell blessing for Israel	33:1-29
<i>Poems as Summary Literary Markers.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020). Adapted from John H. Sailhamer, <i>The Pentateuch as Narrative</i> (1992).		

Each of these riddle-like poems summarizes the themes of the narrative up to that point, and each poem also directs the reader's attention to the main themes in the following story.

Illustrated Reflection on Genesis 3:15

GENESIS 3:15



Reflection on Genesis 3:15. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Yahweh's Curse on the Snake

Notice the snake is the only one cursed in Genesis 3:14-15: "On your belly you will go, you will eat dust." This is imagery of humiliation and defeat ([Mic. 7:17](#)) that is drawn upon by later biblical authors when they depicted the messianic age ([Isa. 65:25](#)). John Sailhamer's reflections on [Genesis 3:15](#) are full of insight on this topic.

"As representatives, the snake and the woman embody the fate of their seed, and the fate of their seed is their fate as well ... At first in verse 15 the 'enmity' is said to have been put between the snake and the woman and between the 'seed' of the snake and the 'seed' of the woman. But the second half of verse 15 states that the 'seed' of the woman ('he') will crush the head of the snake ('your head'). ... Though the 'enmity' may lie between the two 'seeds,' the goal of the final crushing blow is not the 'seed' of the snake but rather the snake itself—his head will be crushed. In other words, it appears that the author is intent on treating the snake and his 'seed' together, as one. What happens to his 'seed' in the distant future can be said to happen to the snake as well. This identification suggests that the author views the snake in terms that extend beyond this particular snake of the Garden. The snake, for the author, is representative of someone or something else, and is represented by his 'seed.' When that 'seed' is crushed, the head of the snake is crushed. Consequently, more is at stake in this brief passage than the reader is at first aware. A program is set forth. A plot is established that will take the author far beyond this or that snake and his 'seed.' It is what the snake and his 'seed' represent that lies at the center of the author's focus. With that 'one' lies the 'enmity' that must be crushed ... If one looks at the passage within the larger scope of the purpose of the Pentateuch ... much more appears to lie in these words ... It seems likely that the author

intends these words to be read as programmatic and foundational for the establishment of the plot and characterization of the remainder of the book. In the narrative to follow, there is to be war ('enmity'). The two sides are represented by two seeds, the 'seed' of the snake and the 'seed' of the woman. In the ensuing battle, the 'seed' of the woman will crush the head of the snake. Though wounded in the struggle, the woman's 'seed' will be victorious. There remains in this verse a puzzling yet important ambiguity: Who is the 'seed' of the woman? It seems obvious that the purpose of verse 15 has not been to answer that question, but rather to raise it. The remainder of the book is, in fact, the author's answer."

Sailhamer, John H. (1995). [*The Pentateuch as Narrative: A Biblical-theological Commentary*](#). Zondervan Academic.

Reflection Question

Who or what is cursed in Genesis 3:14-19? Who or what is not cursed?